such as Oc-Eo in Funan, Palembang in ancient Srivijaya (Indonesia) and Guangzhou in southern China, would have to wait for months before their return trip in order to be able to sail with the seasonal monsoon winds (sailing east from India with the south-west monsoon; sailing west back to India with the north-east monsoon). This provided opportunity for extended contact with local populations and for sustained cultural interchange. Some traders would have settled permanently in these trading ports and over time become part of a mixed population. Recent genetic studies among South-East Asian populations in such locations support such a conclusion.

The later spread of Buddhism in the region took place along these same maritime transmission channels but did not alter the overall cultural matrix. What we witness is a complex blending of the two faiths. Brahmin court priests continued to be in charge of royal rituals even in Buddhist kingdoms, for example in Thailand.

The scripts used in various royal or temple inscriptions were derived from the original Brahmi, which later evolved into a northern form and a southern form in India. Nagari, Siddham and Sharada are examples of the northern scripts. Pallava, Kannada and Vattelutu are categorized as southern scripts. The scripts which found their way to South-East Asia are all derived from the southern scripts, mostly from the old Pallava – for example, the Cham and Khmer scripts of present-day Cambodia, and the scripts currently in use in Thailand, Laos and Myanmar. The vocabulary of these languages contains a significant proportion of Sanskrit loan words. This is strikingly the case with the Indonesian ‘Bahasa’.

At its most expansive phase from the sixth to the fifteenth centuries, the Champa empire presided over a vast trade network which radiated to China, Japan and Korea in the north, to Indonesia and Malaysia in the south, and to India and Sri Lanka in the east. It is not a coincidence that through most of history, what is currently called the South China Sea was known throughout the region as the Champa Sea.

Champa was eventually incorporated into Vietnam, but its legacy survives in the many Cham temples and palaces that are strewn all over central and southern Vietnam. In the tenth century, Islam began to make inroads into